

Ashwin calls it a day

1 “As a cricketer, I’ll just stop and I might go on to be involved with the game because this is a game that has given me everything,” the **legendary spinner** said.

A legend bowed out of the game in a matter-of-fact way at the Gabba on the evening of December 18. Shortly after the third Test concluded in a draw, R. Ashwin accompanied his skipper, Rohit Sharma, to the press conference hall. Soon the ace spinner made it obvious why he was there as he announced his retirement from international cricket with immediate effect.

His statement is as follows: “I really didn’t want to make this about myself. Honestly, I think it would have been better if (Jasprit) Bumrah or Akash Deep were here. But Rohit (Sharma) is unfortunate to have me along his side. I am not going to take too much of your time. This will be my last day as an Indian cricketer in all formats at the international level. I do feel there is a bit of punch left in me as a cricketer, but I would like to

expose and probably showcase that in club-level cricket, but this will be the last day.”

“I have had a lot of fun. I must say I have created a lot of memories alongside Rohit and several of my other teammates, even though I have lost some of them over the last few years. We are the last bunch of OGs. Obviously there are a lot of people to thank, but I would be failing in my duties if I didn’t thank the BCCI and the fellow teammates. I want to name a few of them. All the coaches who have been a part of the journey, most importantly Rohit, Virat (Kohli), Ajinkya (Rahane) and (Cheteshwar) Pujara, who have taken those splendid catches to give me the number of wickets I have managed to get over the years.”

“Also a big thank you to the Australian cricket team, who have

been very fierce competitors. I have enjoyed my time playing against them. I think it is already getting long. I wouldn’t be taking any questions. But it is truly a very emotional moment. I don’t think I am in a position where I would be answering the questions in the right way. So please pardon me for that. Once again, that is my time. Thanks for being the journalists that you have been, writing good things and, of course, writing nasty things on occasions.”

“That’s a relationship I think we would maintain forever, and I hope the cricketers to come in the future will also get the same amount of love. Once again, thank you all, and yeah, see you all soon. As a cricketer, I’ll just stop, and I might go on to be involved with the game because this is a game that has given me everything.”

K. C. Vijaya Kumar